

1980

Seagate And Fortran

February: The ZX80

A British company Sinclair released ZX80 computer for £100 (the equivalent of Rs 16,000 now) in 1980. It is also termed as the first “affordable” home computer taking the price into consideration. Jim Westwood, chief engineer at Sinclair Research, had designed the ZX80 using a Z80 CPU running at a clock speed of 3.25 MHz. The system also had 1 KB SRAM and 4 KB ROM, on which the Sinclair BASIC programming language, editor and operating system were loaded.

Available in two versions—self-assembly and ready built, Sinclair’s distinctive look suited hobbyists and potential home users. The attractive aspect of ZX80 was the membrane based keyboard and the plastic casing, both of them were claimed to be waterproof. The multifunctional keys could be used to enter BASIC-commands at a touch. However, it still had drawbacks: no sound support, no colour and slow program execution. Later an improved version ZX81 was released which was bit cheaper than ZX80.

June: Seagate—Ever A Pioneer

Seagate Technology was formed by Alan Shugart, from Shugart Associates, with Finis Conner, a co-worker at IBM. The company created the first hard disk drive for microcomputers in 1980; it could hold 5 MB of data.

(Note that the first *ever* hard disk, the 305 RAMAC, was invented by IBM in 1956. The storage capacity was five MB on 50 disks, each of which were 24 inches in diameter.)

The hard disk contained a thin metallic platter coated with a magnetic material. After this was launched, Seagate got orders from big customers like Apple Computers and IBM. Through the 1980s, their ST-225 20 MB disk and ST-251 40 MB disk were their best-selling products.